

dismal of D'Arragnan's moods. His head cast down, his eyes fixed, he suffered his legs to hang on each side of his horse, and said to himself, in that vague sort of reverie which ascends sometimes to the sublimest eloquence:

'No more friends! no more future! no more anything! My energies are broken like the bonds of our ancient friendship. Oh, old age is coming, cold and inexorable; it envelopes in its funeral crepe all that was brilliant, all that was embalming in my youth; then it throws that sweet burthen on its shoulders and carries it away with the rest into the fathomless gulf of death.'

A shudder crept through the heart of the Gascon, so brave and so strong against all the misfortunes of life; and during some moments the clouds appeared black to him, the earth slippery and full of pits as that of cemeteries.

'Whither am I going?' said he to himself. 'What am I going to do! Alone, quite alone—without family, without friends! Bah!' cried he all at once. And he clapped spurs to his horse, who, having found nothing melancholy in the heavy oats of Pierrefonds, profited by this permission to show his gayety in a gallop which absorbed two leagues. 'To Paris!' said D'Arragnan to himself. And on the morrow he alighted in Paris. He had devoted ten days to this journey.

Chapter XIX

What D'Arragnan Went to Paris For



HE lieutenant dismounted before a shop in the Rue des Lombards, at the sign of the Pilon d'Or. A man of good appearance, wearing a white apron, and stroking his gray moustache with a large hand, uttered a cry of joy on perceiving the pied horse. 'Monsieur le chevalier,' said he, 'ah, is that you?'

'Bon jour, Planchet,' replied D'Arragnan, stooping to enter the shop.

'Quick, somebody,' cried Planchet, 'to look after Monsieur d'Arragnan's horse,—somebody to get ready his room,—somebody to prepare his supper.'

'Thanks, Planchet. Good-day, my children!' said D'Arragnan to the eager boys.

'Allow me to send off this coffee, this treacle, and these raisins,' said Planchet; 'they are for the store-room of monsieur le suintendant.'

'Send them off, send them off!'

'That is only the affair of a moment, then we shall sup.'

'Arrange it that we may sup alone; I want to speak to you.'

Planchet looked at his old master in a significant manner.

'Oh, don't be uneasy, it is nothing unpleasant,' said D'Arragnan.

'So much the better—so much the better!' And Planchet breathed freely again, whilst D'Arragnan seated himself quietly down in the shop, upon a bale of corks, and made a survey of the premises. The shop was well stocked; there was a mingled perfume of ginger, cinnamon, and ground pepper, which made D'Arragnan sneeze. The shop-boy, proud of being in company with so renowned a warrior, of a lieutenant of musketeers, who approached the

person of the king, began to work with an enthusiasm which was something like delirium, and to serve the customers with a disdainful haste that was noticed by several.

Planchet put away his money, and made up his accounts, amidst civilities addressed to his former master. Planchet had with his equals the short speech and haughty familiarity of the rich shopkeeper who serves everybody and waits for nobody. D'Artagnan observed this habit with a pleasure which we shall analyse presently. He saw night come on by degrees, and at length Planchet conducted him to a chamber on the first story, where, amidst bales and chests, a table very nicely set out awaited the two guests.

D'Artagnan took advantage of a moment's pause to examine the countenance of Planchet, whom he had not seen for a year. The shrewd Planchet had acquired a slight protuberance in front, but his countenance was not puffed. His keen eye still played with facility in its deep-sunk orbit; and fat, which levels all the characteristic saliences of the human face, had not yet touched either his high cheek-bones, the sign of cunning and cupidity, or his pointed chin, the sign of acuteness and perseverance. Planchet reigned with as much majesty in his dining-room as in his shop. He set before his master a frugal, but perfectly Parisian repast: roast meat, cooked at the baker's, with vegetables, salad, and a dessert borrowed from the shop itself. D'Artagnan was pleased that the grocer had drawn from behind the fagots a bottle of that Anjou wine which during all his life had been D'Artagnan's favourite wine.

'Formerly, monsieur,' said Planchet, with a smile full of bonhomie, 'it was I who drank your wine; now you do me the honour to drink mine.'

'And, thank God, friend Planchet, I shall drink it for a long time to come, I hope; for at present I am free.'

'Free? You have a leave of absence, monsieur?'

'Unlimited.'

'You are leaving the service?' said Planchet, stupefied.

'Yes, I am resting.'

'And the king?' cried Planchet, who could not suppose it possible that the king could do without the services of such a man as D'Artagnan.

'The king will try his fortune elsewhere. But we have supped well, you are disposed to enjoy yourself; you invite me to confide in you. Open your ears, then.'

'That is true, monsieur,' said Mousqueton; 'the pleasures have misled us. Well, monsieur, this is the whole affair.'

'I am all attention, Mousqueton.'

'On Wednesday—'

'The day of the rustic pleasures?'

'Yes—a letter arrived; he received it from my hands. I had recognized the writing.'

'Well?'

Monseigneur read it and cried out, 'Quick, my horses! my arms!'

'Oh, good Lord! then it was for some duel?' said D'Artagnan.

'No, monsieur, there were only these words: "Dear Porthos, set out, if you would wish to arrive before the Equinox. I expect you."'

'Mordieux!' said D'Artagnan, thoughtfully, 'that was pressing, apparently.'

'I think so; therefore,' continued Mousqueton, 'monseigneur set out the very same day with his secretary, in order to endeavour to arrive in time.'

'And did he arrive in time?'

'I hope so. Monseigneur, who is hasty, as you know, monsieur, repeated incessantly, "Tonne Dieu! What can this mean? The Equinox? Never mind, a fellow must be well mounted to arrive before I do."'

'And you think Porthos will have arrived first, do you?' asked D'Artagnan.

'I am sure of it. This Equinox, however rich he may be, has certainly no horses so good as monseigneur's.'

D'Artagnan repressed his inclination to laugh, because the brevity of Aramis's letter gave rise to reflection. He followed Mousqueton, or rather Mousqueton's chariot, to the castle. He sat down to a sumptuous table, of which they did him the honours as to a king. But he could draw nothing from Mousqueton,—the faithful servant seemed to shed tears at will, but that was all.

D'Artagnan, after a night passed in an excellent bed, reflected much upon the meaning of Aramis's letter; puzzled himself as to the relation of the Equinox with the affairs of Porthos; and being unable to make anything out unless it concerned some amour of the bishop's, for which it was necessary that the days and nights should be equal, D'Artagnan left Pierrefonds as he had left Melun, as he had left the château of the Comte de la Fère. It was not, however, without a melancholy, which might in good sooth pass for one of the most

after supper, as a joke, he struck the wall a blow. The wall crumbled away beneath his hand, the roof fell in, and three men and an old woman were stifled.'

'Good God, Mousqueton! And your master?'

'Oh, monseigneur, a little skin was rubbed off his head. We bathed the wounds with some water which the monks gave us. But there was nothing the matter with his hand.'

'Nothing?'

'No, nothing, monsieur.'

'Deuce take the Olympic pleasures! They must cost your master too dear; for widows and orphans—'

'They all had pensions, monsieur; a tenth of monseigneur's revenue was spent in that way.'

'Then pass on to Friday,' said D'Artagnan.

'Friday, noble and warlike pleasures. We hunt, we fence, we dress falcons and break horses. Then, Saturday is the day for intellectual pleasures: we adorn our minds; we look at monseigneur's pictures and statues; we write, even, and trace plans; and then we fire monseigneur's cannon.'

'You draw plans, and fire cannon?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Why, my friend,' said D'Artagnan, 'M. du Vallon, in truth, possesses the most subtle and amiable mind that I know. But there is one kind of pleasure you have forgotten, it appears to me.'

'What is that, monsieur?' asked Mousqueton, with anxiety.

'The material pleasures.'

Mousqueton coloured. 'What do you mean by that, monsieur?' said he, casting down his eyes.

'I mean the table—good wine—evenings occupied in passing the bottle.'

'Ah, monsieur, we don't reckon those pleasures,—we practice them every day.'

'My brave Mousqueton,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'pardon me, but I was so absorbed in your charming recital that I have forgotten the principal object of our conversation, which was to learn what M. le Vicaire-General d'Herblay could have to write to your master about.'

'They are open.' And Planchet, with a laugh more frank than cunning, opened a bottle of white wine.

'Leave me my reason, at least.'

'Oh, as to you losing your head—you, monsieur!'

'Now my head is my own, and I mean to take better care of it than ever. In the first place we shall talk business. How fares our money-box?'

'Wonderfully well, monsieur. The twenty thousand livres I had of you are still employed in my trade, in which they bring me nine per cent. I give you seven, so I gain two by you.'

'And you are still satisfied?'

'Delighted. Have you brought me any more?'

'Better than that. But do you want any?'

'Oh! not at all. Every one is willing to trust me now. I am extending my business.'

'That was your intention.'

'I play the banker a little. I buy goods of my needy brethren; I lend money to those who are not ready for their payments.'

'Without usury?'

'Oh! monsieur, in the course of the last week I have had two meetings on the boulevards, on account of the word you have just pronounced.'

'What?'

'You shall see: it concerned a loan. The borrower gives me in pledge some raw sugars, on condition that I should sell if repayment were not made within a fixed period. I lend a thousand livres. He does not pay me, and I sell the sugars for thirteen hundred livres. He learns this and claims a hundred crowns. Ma foi! I refused, pretending that I could not sell them for more than nine hundred livres. He accused me of usury. I begged him to repeat that word to me behind the boulevards. He was an old guard, and he came: and I passed your sword through his left thigh.'

'Tu dieu! what a pretty sort of banker you make!' said D'Artagnan.

'For above thirteen per cent I fight,' replied Planchet; 'that is my character.'

'Take only twelve,' said D'Artagnan, 'and call the rest premium and brokerage.'

'You are right, monsieur; but to your business.'

'Ah! Planchet, it is very long and very hard to speak.'

'Do speak it, nevertheless.'

D'Arragnan twisted his moustache like a man embarrassed with the confidence he is about to make and mistrustful of his confidant.

'Is it an investment?' asked Planchet.

'Why, yes.'

'At good profit?'

'A capital profit,—four hundred per cent, Planchet.'

Planchet gave such a blow with his fist upon the table, that the bottles bounded as if they had been frightened.

'Good heavens! is that possible?'

'I think it will be more,' replied D'Arragnan coolly; 'but I like to lay it at the lowest!'

'The devil!' said Planchet, drawing nearer. 'Why, monsieur, that is magnificent! Can one put much money in it?'

'Twenty thousand livres each, Planchet.'

'Why, that is all you have, monsieur. For how long a time?'

'For a month.'

'And that will give us—'

'Fifty thousand livres each, profit.'

'It is monstrous! It is worth while to fight for such interest as that!'

'In fact, I believe it will be necessary to fight not a little,' said D'Arragnan, with the same tranquillity; 'but this time there are two of us, Planchet, and I shall take all the blows to myself.'

'Oh! monsieur, I will not allow that.'

'Planchet, you cannot be concerned in it; you would be obliged to leave your business and your family.'

'The affair is not in Paris, then.'

'No.'

'Abroad?'

'In England.'

'A speculative country, that is true,' said Planchet,—'a country that I know well. What sort of an affair, monsieur, without too much curiosity?'

'Planchet, it is a restoration.'

'Of monuments?'

'Yes, of monuments; we shall restore Whitehall.'

'Good!' cried D'Arragnan. 'What are they? Detail them, my dear Mousqueton.'

'Monseigneur has bought a sphere or globe, which I shall show you; it fills all the perimeter of the great tower, except a gallery which he has had built over the sphere: there are little strings and brass wires to which the sun and moon are hooked. It all turns; and that is very beautiful. Monseigneur points out to me the seas and distant countries. We don't intend to visit them, but it is very interesting.'

'Interesting! yes, that's the word,' repeated D'Arragnan. 'And Wednesday?'

'Rustic pleasures, as I have had the honour to tell you, monsieur le chevalier.

We look over monseigneur's sheep and goats; we make the shepherds dance to pipes and reeds, as is written in a book monseigneur has in his library, which is called "Bergeries." The author died about a month ago.'

'Monsieur Racan, perhaps,' said D'Arragnan.

'Yes, that was his name—M. Racan. But that is not all: we angle in the little canal, after which we dine, crowned with flowers. That is Wednesday.'

'Peste!' said D'Arragnan; 'you don't divide your pleasures badly. And Thursday?—what can be left for poor Thursday?'

'It is not very unfortunate, monsieur,' said Mousqueton, smiling. 'Thursday, Olympian pleasures. Ah, monsieur, that is superb! We get together all monseigneur's young vassals, and we make them throw the disc, wrestle, and run races. Monseigneur can't run now, no more can I; but monseigneur throws the disc as nobody else can throw it. And when he does deal a blow, oh, that proves a misfortune!'

'How so?'

'Yes, monsieur, we were obliged to renounce the cestus. He cracked heads; he broke jaws—beat in ribs. It was charming sport; but nobody was willing to play with him.'

'Then his wrist—'

'Oh, monsieur, firmer than ever. Monseigneur gets a trifle weaker in his legs,—he confesses that himself; but his strength has all taken refuge in his arms, so that—'

'So that he can knock down bullocks, as he used to formerly.'

'Monsieur, better than that—he beats in walls. Lately, after having supped with one of our farmers—you know how popular and kind monseigneur is—'

'How easily do I recognize Porthos's love of order in that! Now, that idea would never have occurred to me; but then I am not encumbered with pleasures.'

'We were, though,' said Mousqueton.

'And how did you regulate the matter, let me know?' said D'Artagnan.

'It is rather long, monsieur.'

'Never mind, we have plenty of time; and you speak so well, my dear Mousqueton, that it is really a pleasure to hear you.'

'It is true,' said Mousqueton, with a sigh of satisfaction, which emanated evidently from the justice which had been rendered him, 'it is true I have made great progress in the company of monseigneur.'

'I am waiting for the distribution of the pleasures, Mousqueton, and with impatience. I want to know if I have arrived on a lucky day.'

'Oh, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said Mousqueton in a melancholy tone, 'since monseigneur's departure all the pleasures have gone too!'

'Well, my dear Mousqueton, refresh your memory.'

'With what day shall I begin?'

'Eh, pardieux! begin with Sunday; that is the Lord's day.'

'Sunday, monsieur?'

'Yes.'

'Sunday pleasures are religious: monseigneur goes to mass, makes the bread-offering, and has discourses and instructions made to him by his almoner-in-ordinary. That is not very amusing, but we expect a Carmelite from Paris who will do the duty of our almoner, and who, we are assured, speaks very well, which will keep us awake, whereas our present almoner always sends us to sleep. These are Sunday religious pleasures. On Monday, worldly pleasures.'

'Ah, ah!' said D'Artagnan, 'what do you mean by that? Let us have a glimpse at your worldly pleasures.'

'Monsieur, on Monday we go into the world; we pay and receive visits, we play on the lute, we dance, we make verses, and burn a little incense in honour of the ladies.'

'Peste! that is the height of gallantry,' said the musketeer, who was obliged to call to his aid all the strength of his facial muscles to suppress an enormous inclination to laugh.

'Tuesday, learned pleasures.'

'That is important. And in a month, you think?'

'I shall undertake it.'

'That concerns you, monsieur, and when once you are engaged—'

'Yes, that concerns me. I know what I am about; nevertheless, I will freely consult with you.'

'You do me great honour; but I know very little about architecture.'

'Planchet, you are wrong; you are an excellent architect, quite as good as I am, for the case in question.'

'Thanks, monsieur. But your old friends of the musketeers?'

'I have been, I confess, tempted to speak of the thing to those gentlemen, but they are all absent from their houses. It is vexatious, for I know none more bold or able.'

'Ah! then it appears there will be an opposition, and the enterprise will be disputed?'

'Oh, yes, Planchet, yes.'

'I burn to know the details, monsieur.'

'Here they are, Planchet—close all the doors tight.'

'Yes, monsieur.' And Planchet double-locked them.

'That is well, now draw near.' Planchet obeyed.

'And open the window, because the noise of the passers-by and the carts will deafen all who might hear us.' Planchet opened the window as desired, and the gust of tumult which filled the chamber with cries, wheels, barking, and steps deafened D'Artagnan himself, as he had wished. He then swallowed a glass of white wine, and began in these terms: 'Planchet, I have an idea.'

'Ah! monsieur, I recognize you so well in that!' replied Planchet, panting with emotion.

'Mon Dieu, monsieur!' said Mousqueton, as if rousing himself from a painful reverie; 'how happy monseigneur will be that you have thought of him!'

'Kind Porthos!' cried D'Artagnan, 'I am anxious to embrace him.'

'Oh!' said Mousqueton, much affected, 'I shall certainly write to him.'

'What!' cried D'Artagnan, 'you will write to him?'

'This very day; I shall not delay it an hour.'

'Is he not here, then?'

'No, monsieur.'

'But is he near at hand?—is he far off?'

'Oh, can I tell, monsieur, can I tell?'

'Mordieux!' cried the musketeer, stamping with his foot, 'I am unfortunate.'

Porthos is such a stay-at-home!

'Monsieur, there is not a more sedentary man than monseigneur, but—'

'But what?'

'When a friend presses you—'

'A friend?'

'Doubtless—the worthy M. d'Herblay.'

'What, has Aramis pressed Porthos?'

'This is how the thing happened, Monsieur d'Artagnan. M. d'Herblay wrote to monseigneur—'

'Indeed!'

'A letter, monsieur, such a pressing letter that it threw us all into a bustle.'

'Tell me all about it, my dear friend,' said D'Artagnan; 'but remove these people a little further off first.'

Mousqueton shouted, 'Fall back, you fellows,' with such powerful lungs that the breath, without the words, would have been sufficient to disperse the four lackeys. D'Artagnan seated himself on the shaft of the box and opened his ears. 'Monsieur,' said Mousqueton, 'monseigneur, then, received a letter from M. le Vicaire-General d'Herblay, eight or nine days ago; it was the day of the rustic pleasures, yes, it must have been Wednesday.'

'What do you mean?' said D'Artagnan. 'The day of rustic pleasures?'

'Yes, monsieur; we have so many pleasures to take in this delightful country, that we were encumbered by them; so much so, that we have been forced to regulate the distribution of them.'

thing D'Artagnan perceived after the fine trees, the May sun gilding the sides of the green hills, the long rows of feather-topped trees which stretched out towards Compiegne, was a large rolling box, pushed forward by two servants and dragged by two others. In this box there was an enormous green-and-gold thing, which went along the smiling glades of the park, thus dragged and pushed. This thing, at a distance, could not be distinguished, and signified absolutely nothing; nearer, it was a hogshhead muffled in gold-bound green cloth; when close, it was a man, or rather a poussa, the inferior extremity of whom, spreading over the interior of the box, entirely filled it; when still closer, the man was Mousqueton—Mousqueton, with gray hair and a face as red as Punchinello's.

'Pardieu!' cried D'Artagnan; 'why, that's my dear Monsieur Mousqueton!' 'Ah!' cried the fat man—'ah! what happiness! what joy! There's M. d'Artagnan. Stop, you rascals!' These last words were addressed to the lackeys who pushed and dragged him. The box stopped, and the four lackeys, with a precision quite military, took off their laced hats and ranged themselves behind it.

'Oh, Monsieur d'Artagnan!' said Mousqueton, 'why can I not embrace your knees? But I have become impotent, as you see.'

'Dame! my dear Mousqueton, it is age.'

'No, monsieur, it is not age; it is infirmities—troubles.'

'Troubles! you, Mousqueton?' said D'Artagnan, making the tour of the box; 'are you out of your mind, my dear friend? Thank God! you are as hearty as a three-hundred-year-old oak.'

'Ah! but my legs, monsieur, my legs!' groaned the faithful servant.

'What's the matter with your legs?'

'Oh, they will no longer bear me!'

'Ah, the ungrateful things! And yet you feed them well, Mousqueton, apparently.'

'Alas, yes! They can reproach me with nothing in that respect,' said Mousqueton, with a sigh; 'I have always done what I could for my poor body; I am not selfish.' And Mousqueton sighed afresh.

'I wonder whether Mousqueton wants to be a baron, too, as he sighs after that fashion?' thought D'Artagnan.

Chapter XX

Of the Society which was Formed in the Rue des Lombards



AFTER a moment's silence, in which D'Artagnan appeared to be collecting, not one idea but all his ideas,—'It cannot be, my dear Planchet,' said he, 'that you have not heard of his majesty Charles I of England?'

'Alas! yes, monsieur, since you left France in order to assist him, and that, in spite of that assistance, he fell, and was near dragging you down in his fall.'

'Exactly so; I see you have a good memory, Planchet.'

'Peste! the astonishing thing would be, if I could have lost that memory, however bad it might have been. When one has heard Grimaud, who, you know, is not given to talking, relate how the head of King Charles fell, how you sailed the half of a night in a scuttled vessel, and saw floating on the water that good M. Mordaunt with a certain gold-hafted dagger buried in his breast, one is not very likely to forget such things.'

'And yet there are people who forget them, Planchet.'

'Yes, such as have not seen them, or have not heard Grimaud relate them.'

'Well, it is all the better that you recollect all that; I shall only have to remind you of one thing, and that is that Charles I had a son.'

'Without contradicting you, monsieur, he had two,' said Planchet; 'for I saw the second one in Paris, M. le Duke of York, one day, as he was going to the Palais Royal, and I was told that he was not the eldest son of Charles I. As to the eldest, I have the honour of knowing him by name, but not personally.'

‘That is exactly the point, Planchet, we must come to: it is to this eldest son, formerly called the Prince of Wales, and who is now styled Charles II, king of England.’

‘A king without a kingdom, monsieur,’ replied Planchet, sententiously.

‘Yes, Planchet, and you may add an unfortunate prince, more unfortunate than the poorest man of the people lost in the worst quarter of Paris.’

Planchet made a gesture full of that sort of compassion which we grant to strangers with whom we think we can never possibly find ourselves in contact. Besides, he did not see in this politico-sentimental operation any sign of the commercial idea of M. d’Aragnan, and it was in this idea that D’Aragnan, who was, from habit, pretty well acquainted with men and things, had principally interested Planchet.

‘I am come to our business. This young Prince of Wales, a king without a kingdom, as you have so well said, Planchet, has interested me. I, D’Aragnan, have seen him begging assistance of Mazarin, who is a miser, and the aid of Louis, who is a child, and it appeared to me, who am acquainted with such things, that in the intelligent eye of the fallen king, in the nobility of his whole person, a nobility apparent above all his miseries, I could discern the stuff of a man and the heart of a king.’

Planchet tacitly approved of all this; but it did not at all, in his eyes at least, throw any light upon D’Aragnan’s idea. The latter continued: ‘This, then, is the reasoning which I made with myself. Listen attentively, Planchet, for we are coming to the conclusion.’

‘I am listening.’

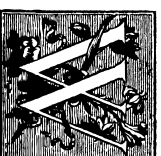
‘Kings are not so thickly sown upon the earth, that people can find them whenever they want them. Now, this king without a kingdom is, in my opinion, a grain of seed which will blossom in some season or other, provided a skilful, discreet, and vigorous hand sow it duly and truly, selecting soil, sky, and time.’

Planchet still approved by a nod of his head, which showed that he did not perfectly comprehend all that was said.

“‘Poor little seed of a king,” said I to myself, and really I was affected, Planchet, which leads me to think I am entering upon a foolish business. And that is why I wished to consult you, my friend.’

Planchet coloured with pleasure and pride.

Chapter XVIII In Which D’Aragnan Seeks Porthos, and Only Finds Mousqueton



WHEN D’Aragnan had perfectly convinced himself that the absence of the Vicar-General d’Herblay was real, and that his friend was not to be found at Melun or in its vicinity, he left Bazin without regret, cast an ill-natured glance at the magnificent château de Vaux, which was beginning to shine with that splendour which brought on its ruin, and, compressing his lips like a man full of mistrust and suspicion, he put spurs to his pied horse, saying, ‘Well, well! I have still Pierrefonds left, and there I shall find the best man and the best filled coffer. And that is all I want, for I have an idea of my own.’

We will spare our readers the prosaic incidents of D’Aragnan’s journey, which terminated on the morning of the third day within sight of Pierrefonds. D’Aragnan came by the way of Nanteuil-le-Haudouin and Crepy. At a distance he perceived the Castle of Louis of Orleans, which, having become part of the crown domain, was kept by an old concierge. This was one of those marvellous manors of the middle ages, with walls twenty feet in thickness, and a hundred in height.

D’Aragnan rode slowly past its walls, measured its towers with his eye and descended into the valley. From afar he looked down upon the château of Porthos, situated on the shores of a small lake, and contiguous to a magnificent forest. It was the same place we have already had the honour of describing to our readers, we shall therefore satisfy ourselves with naming it. The first

“Poor little seed of a king! I will pick you up and cast you into good ground.”

‘Good God!’ said Planchet, looking earnestly at his old master, as if in doubt as to the state of his reason.

‘Well, what is it?’ said D’Arragnan; ‘who hurts you?’

‘Me! nothing, monsieur.’

‘You said, “Good God!”’

‘Did I?’

‘I am sure you did. Can you already understand?’

‘I confess, M. d’Arragnan, that I am afraid—’

‘To understand?’

‘Yes.’

‘To understand that I wish to replace upon his throne this King Charles II, who has no throne? Is that it?’

Planchet made a prodigious bound in his chair. ‘Ah, ah!’ said he, in evident terror, ‘that is what you call a restoration!’

‘Yes, Planchet; is it not the proper term for it?’

‘Oh, no doubt, no doubt! But have you reflected seriously?’

‘Upon what?’

‘Upon what is going on yonder.’

‘Where?’

‘In England.’

‘And what is that? Let us see, Planchet.’

‘In the first place, monsieur, I ask you pardon for meddling in these things, which have nothing to do with my trade; but since it is an affair that you propose to me—for you are proposing an affair, are you not?—’

‘A superb one, Planchet.’

‘But as it is business you propose to me, I have the right to discuss it.’

‘Discuss it, Planchet; out of discussion is born light.’

‘Well, then, since I have monsieur’s permission, I will tell him that there is yonder, in the first place, the parliament.’

‘Well, next?’

‘And then the army.’

‘Good! Do you see anything else?’

‘Why, then the nation.’

'Is that all?'

'The nation which consented to the overthrow and death of the late king, the father of this one, and which will not be willing to belie its acts.'

'Planchet,' said D'Artagnan, 'you argue like a cheese! The nation—the nation is tired of these gentlemen who give themselves such barbarous names, and who sing songs to it. Chanting for chanting, my dear Planchet; I have remarked that nations prefer singing a merry chant to the plain chant. Remember the Fronde; what did they sing in those times? Well, those were good times.'

'Not too good, not too good! I was near being hung in those times.'

'Well, but you were not.'

'No.'

'And you laid the foundations of your fortune in the midst of all those songs?'

'That is true.'

'Then you have nothing to say against them.'

'Well, I return, then, to the army and parliament.'

'I say that I borrow twenty thousand livres of M. Planchet, and that I put twenty thousand livres of my own to it; and with these forty thousand livres I raise an army.'

Planchet clasped his hands; he saw that D'Artagnan was in earnest, and, in good truth, he believed his master had lost his senses.

'An army!—ah, monsieur,' said he, with his most agreeable smile, for fear of irritating the madman, and rendering him furious,—'an army!—how many?'

'Of forty men,' said D'Artagnan.

'Forty against forty thousand! that is not enough. I know very well that you, M. d'Artagnan, alone, are equal to a thousand men; but where are we to find thirty-nine men equal to you? Or, if we could find them, who would furnish you with money to pay them?'

'Not bad, Planchet. Ah, the devil! you play the courier.'

'No, monsieur, I speak what I think, and that is exactly why I say that, in the first pitched battle you fight with your forty men, I am very much afraid—'

'Therefore I shall fight no pitched battles, my dear Planchet,' said the Gascon, laughing. 'We have very fine examples in antiquity of skilful retreats and marches, which consisted in avoiding the enemy instead of attacking them.'

was the concluding word by the aid of which D'Artagnan, having become wise, now terminated every thought and every period of his style. Formerly he said, 'Mordieux!' which was a prick of the spur, but now he had become older, and he murmured that philosophical 'Bah!' which served as a bridle to all the passions.